

ROBERT CAMPBELL

An eccentric kind of place

In architecture, it's a long way from an interesting idea to a good building.

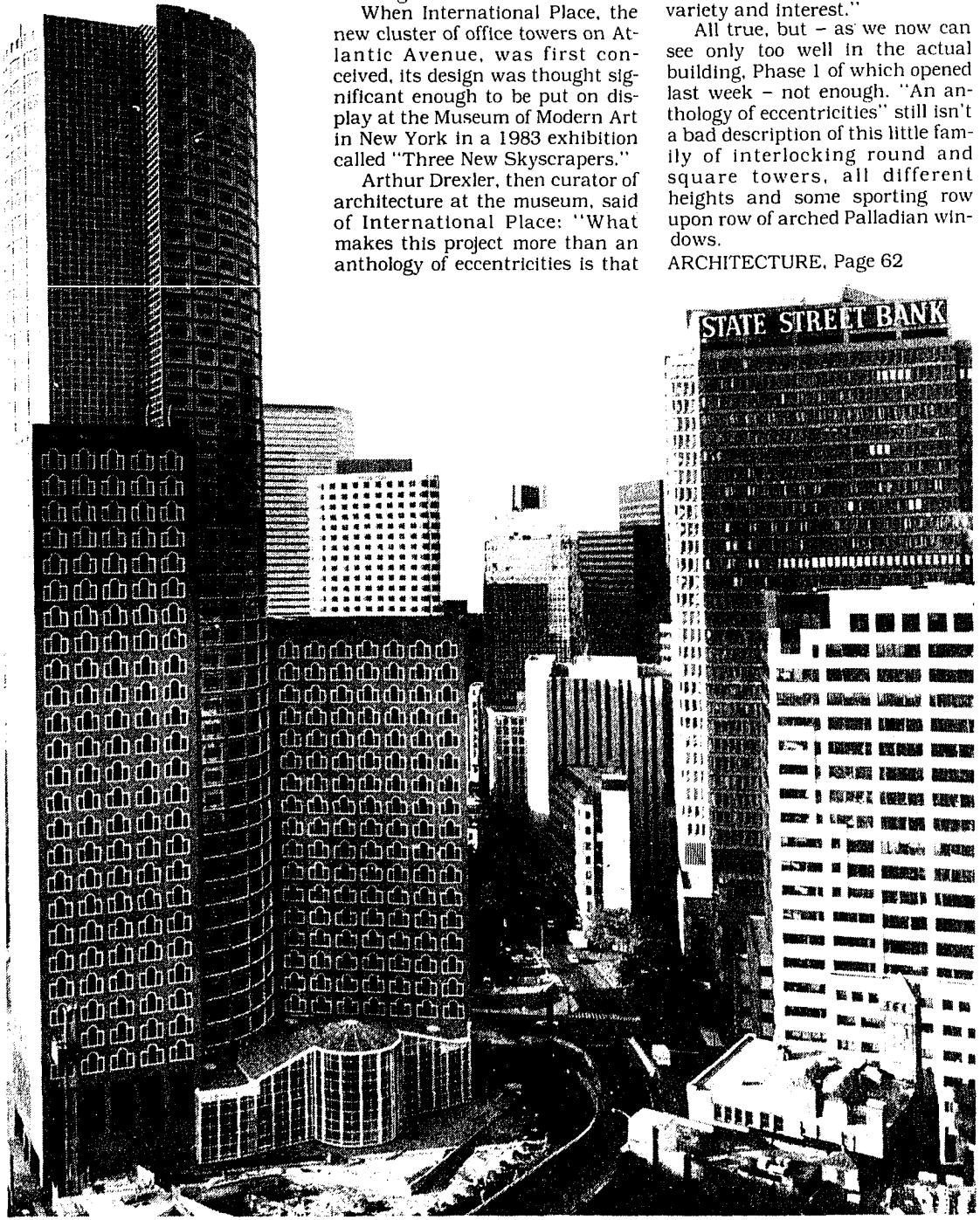
When International Place, the new cluster of office towers on Atlantic Avenue, was first conceived, its design was thought significant enough to be put on display at the Museum of Modern Art in New York in a 1983 exhibition called "Three New Skyscrapers."

Arthur Drexler, then curator of architecture at the museum, said of International Place: "What makes this project more than an anthology of eccentricities is that

it achieves its goals: It does modulate urban scale, it does solve its site problems and it does provide variety and interest."

All true, but – as we now can see only too well in the actual building, Phase 1 of which opened last week – not enough. "An anthology of eccentricities" still isn't a bad description of this little family of interlocking round and square towers, all different heights and some sporting row upon row of arched Palladian windows.

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International Place looks more like a model of a building than the real thing.

A complex, eccentric International Place

■ ARCHITECTURE

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A more pungent description gained local fame a couple of years later. One of the architects, the ebullient octogenarian Philip Johnson, described his own building as "two million goddam square feet that shouldn't be built in this part of Boston."

Four years later, International Place has moved from a model in a museum to a reality in Boston. It's been pretty much downhill all the way.

Let's talk first, though, since no one else seems to be doing so, about International Place's initial virtues. The most obvious is that the building is not a bore. People have been reacting to it and talking about it since it first was proposed. More Bostonians now know what a Palladian window is than would once have seemed possible. The second virtue is the astonishing way in which the enormous bulk of this building has been broken down in scale and fitted into downtown Boston. Our downtown is not a grid but a twisting network of streets and alleys. And Boston is not a flat city like Chicago but a hilly one. International Place, as a concept, is a brilliant and wholly original response to these conditions.

Looking at its informal jumble of heights and shapes you sense the irregularity, the picturesqueness of our city. And by designing one big building to look like a cluster of smaller ones, the architects — John Burgee Architects, of which Johnson is the former senior partner — have disguised its size. Seen from a distance, it looks like several shapes, not one, and — although it's the biggest and tallest tower downtown — it settles into the skyline comfortably with much smaller neighbors.

A third virtue is the building's attitude to the street. International Place has a triangular site. Twenty years ago, any architect would have put a box in the middle of the site and called the windy leftover space a plaza. Johnson and Burgee instead locate the empty space in the middle, as a glass-roofed eating court, pushing the building itself out to the edges where it can define the streetspace and provide some life to the sidewalk.

A fourth virtue is retail activity. There will be several restaurants spilling tables out onto the eating court, and there are purely practical features, too — a tailor and a dry cleaner and a news dealer and a shoe repair shop. No shops open right off the sidewalk,

as they should, but International Place is still a far cry from the pompous vacuity of the lower levels of, say, the Bank of Boston or One Boston Place.

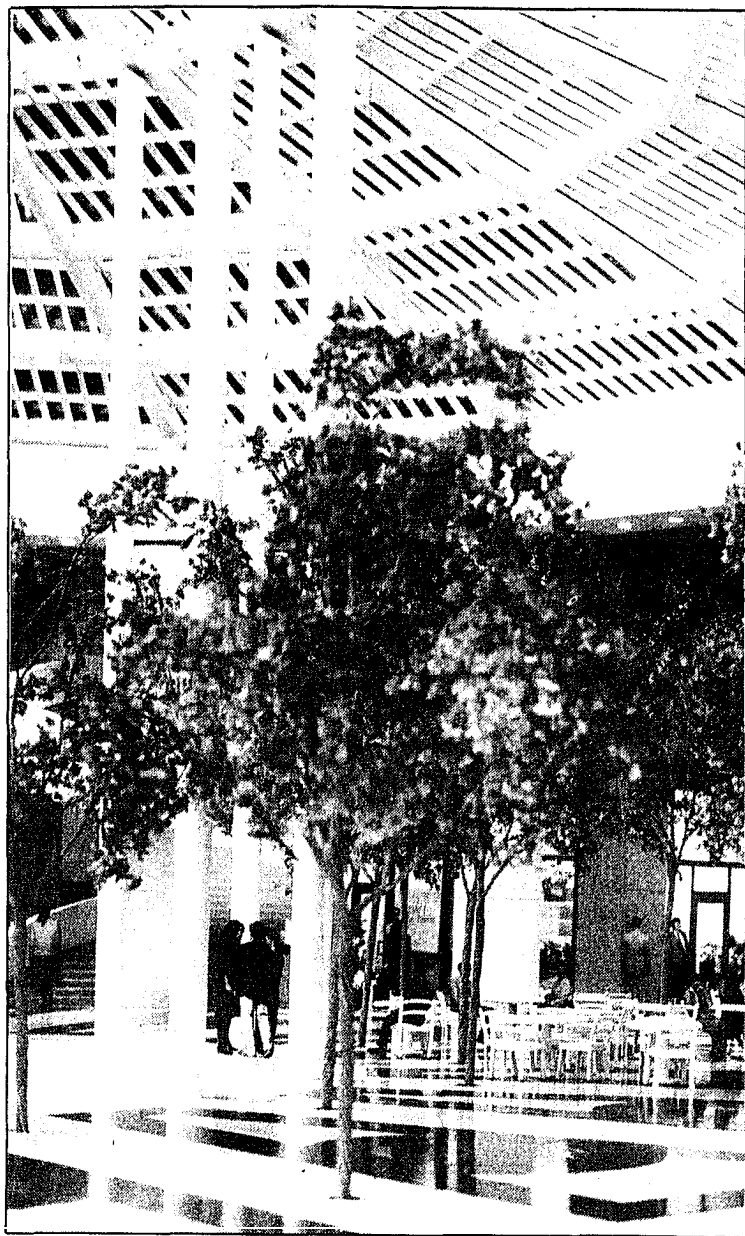
A fifth virtue is the shape of the floors. The tenants' interior designers must have gone nuts dealing with the loony floor plans that result from the intersection of round and square buildings. But they've responded to the challenge and, again and again, created far more interesting interior spaces than are usual in Boston. And the high ratio of exterior wall to interior floor makes for a lot of light and a lot of outside offices.

At this point, International Place runs out of virtues. What's left is its architectural expression, and that is terrible. The whole complex appears to be made out of thin pinkish cardboard — actually it's granite — punctured by white window frames that are as featureless as Styrofoam. Everything is so thin and diagrammatic that you feel you are looking at a model of a building instead of the real thing.

Across Atlantic Avenue, by contrast, the new Rowes Wharf offers a sense of solidity and rich detail that are totally lacking at International Place. Johnson and Burgee might argue — they don't, but they might — that International Place is simply being more honest than Rowes Wharf. Both, after all, are made of a steel frame onto which an exterior skin has been hung. But where Rowes pretends to be a load-bearing masonry structure like those of Boston's past, International Place clearly expresses the real nature of modern construction: a skin wrapping a frame.

The endless rows of Palladian windows, which look as if King Kong had stenciled them on the building, can thus be seen as a poignant expression of the true wallpaperish construction. The fact that the windows' arched tops don't even appear indoors, where they seem to be rectangles, only emphasizes the fact that they are mere wrapping paper. Beyond all that, the windows express the media world we now live in, where image replaces reality. They are graphic design rather than architecture: they intentionally say "architecture" rather than create any.

That's the only kind of argument I can concoct that makes sense of International Place intellectually. Certainly it fails completely as experience. No one wants buildings that look this



Drawing of the glass-roofed eating court at International Place.

cheap, flat and insubstantial; no one enjoys details that seem stenciled on. We want a greater richness of detail in our buildings, and throughout history have been perfectly willing to get this richness in the form of fiction rather than "honest" expression.

Indoors the same appalling thinness of detail is everywhere. Elaborate orange marble fills the lobbies, taking the form of traditional architectural motifs such as pilasters, arches and cornices. Though it is real solid marble, it is detailed so crudely you feel as if it were canvas in a stage set, or as if it were plastic sheets you could peel off. You feel you are inside an enormous candy box. Nothing feels real or substantial. Elevators are paneled in framed rectangles of marble, so that they look like displays in a marble showroom — a Johnson-Burgee trademark. Ironwork light fixtures at the main entrances, another trademark, are as usual so huge and so unrelated to anything else that

they become a surreal joke. Perhaps they are supposed to make the rest of the building look smaller in photographs.

In many ways, International Place is the last building of a generation. Obviously, it's too big — as noted above, Johnson himself thinks so — but that's not the fault of the architect or the developer, Donald J. Chiofaro. It's the fault of the planning process under Mayor Kevin White. All White cared about was selling the site (which housed a city-owned garage) for all he could get. The more bulk the city permitted, the more bucks it got for the garage. What we see now is only Phase 1 of International Place, somewhat more than half the total. When the whole colossus is finished, it will probably amount to around a million and a half square feet, not much less than the Hancock Tower. We will see no more such behemoths in Boston. But International Place should nevertheless be completed. It is amputated and raw today and is much worse than if it were whole.

International Place was a strong architectural and urban concept at the beginning. As completed, it's still better than the typical downtown office building. But as with most of the work of Burgee and Johnson, the care and thought seem to have stopped with the initial concept. The building hasn't been carried through with devotion. It remains a diagram.